he is the Commander's right-hand man. What he says about you, me and the unit is what the Cdr will believe.' As I turned round at the door to salute, he was back at work—book in his left hand, twirling his moustache with the right.

One of the exercises we participated in during that tenure was Ex Digvijay, one of the largest exercises to have been held till then. It was a predominantly mechanized warfare exercise, meant to send a message to Pakistan. As part of the exercise, we advanced more than 45 km on foot over two nights to reach the objective area, navigating only by the compass—there was no GPS then. My immediate senior, Lt Vivek Ananthakrishnan, and I were in charge of the navigation. Two parties had been made by design, each under one of us, to be doubly sure. At the end of two days of night navigation, we hit the target within half a km of the planned spot, such was the proficiency we had acquired. During the day's enforced halt, sheltering below whatever little cover there was, the CO spread out his ground sheet and ordered me to go to sleep.

Bikaner was not just about exercises in the desert. As a peace station, the families of the married officers joined and we had several parties. A favourite picnic spot was on the Bikaner Lift Canal. The bachelors calling on the senior officers was a regular feature. Our favourite target for these 'raids', usually after midnight, was Capt JK Maindiratta. We would also call on Capt AVS Ghuman with some trepidation, but he was a most gracious host, his office scowl replaced by a warm welcoming smile. It taught us another lesson of how to separate the professional and the personal, and of how not to carry workplace tensions home that could affect the whole family. There were five of us subalterns—Vivek, Yogender Singh, Lajpat Rai, Ramesh Menon and myself. Yogender unfortunately had a severe back problem and left the Army to join the Haryana

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